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STEM OPT Extension Based on a Prior Degree

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What Is a STEM OPT Extension Based on a Prior Degree?

If a student has completed a bachelor's, master's or doctoral STEM-designated degree program at a U.S. institution before their most recent degree, they may be eligible for a STEM OPT Extension based on that prior degree. If a student is currently engaging in Post-Completion OPT authorized on their most recently awarded non-STEM degree, they could potentially extend their OPT through a STEM OPT Extension based on their prior degree.

For example, a student could:

1. Receive a STEM-designated degree such
2. Then complete a non-STEM-designated iterature.
3. Receive 12 months of Post-Completion re.

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- Must work for an employer that meets all of the STEM OPT employment requirements.
- Must begin STEM-eligible employment on or before the STEM OPT Extension start date.
- Must have submitted the STEM OPT application to USCIS before their Post-Completion EAD end date. USCIS will not accept applications received after the Post-Completion OPT EAD end date. In addition to these filing dates, students must consider other important dates when applying for STEM OPT.
- Must be in the United States to file the Form I-765.
- Must have completed a bachelor's, master's or doctoral STEM-designated degree program at a U.S. institution. Students can determine whether a degree program is STEM-designated by checking whether the CIP code on page 1 of the Form I-20 issued for the program appears in the U.S. Department of Homeland Security's list of STEM-designated programs. The qualifying degree must be on this list at the time of application for the STEM OPT Extension.

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How to Apply for a STEM OPT Extension Based on a Prior Degree

The application process for a STEM OPT Extension based on a prior degree must be completed in this order:

1. The student meets with an OIS advisor to determine eligibility for STEM OPT Extension based on a prior degree.
2. The student and employer complete Form I-983.
3. The student submits STEM OPT Extension I-20 Request (Prior Degree) via Trojan International.
4. The student receives STEM OPT I-20 from OIS via USC email.
5. The student files Form I-765, STEM OPT I-20 and supporting documents to USCIS.
6. USCIS adjudicates the student's STEM O
7. The student receives USCIS approval no

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required form and serves as the official source of information.

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Requesting a STEM OPT Extension I-20 (Prior Degree)

When to Submit the STEM OPT Extension I-20 (Prior Degree) Request to OIS

Calculating STEM OPT Start and End Dates

How to Request a STEM OPT I-20 from OIS

Receiving the STEM OPT Extension I-20 (Pr

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Changes to Employment While Form I-765 is Pending With USCIS

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USCIS Application Decision

After filing Form I-765 online with the supporting documents and filing fee, students will be issued the "I-797C Notice of Action: Receipt." This includes a receipt number, which they can use to check their case status.

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If you filed the Form I-907, Request for Premium Processing Service, USCIS guarantees a response within 30 business days.

Automatic 180-Day Extension

Receiving STEM OPT Extension Approval From USCIS

How to Request a Replacement EAD for an Error Made by USCIS

How to Request a Replacement EAD for Lost/Stolen/Damaged/Student Error

STEM OPT Extension Rejection, Request for Evidence, Notice of Intent to Deny, or Denial

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Travel and Reentry to the United States While on STEM OPT

Please refer to our requirements for reentry

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